

Yawn!

THAT WAS MY REACTION when Ed insisted that we also do an entire extra magazine based on the technology developments of the Next Decade. Not because I thought the idea was boring... but because he told us at 2 am on a video conference call on a Sunday. Pretty standard for life at Digit actually, but I really was sleepy that day!

A few days later when he told me I'd be expected to write an entire column on the topic, and a serious one at that, not my usual flip-pant rambling. Not that he hates my rambling, because apparently some of you have written in to him to share your appreciation, which is just insane. What's wrong with you people that in a team of awesome writers you write in to appreciate the idiot who complains about everything?

Getting down to it, because I promised Ed I'd stay on topic... what are the biggest changes I see happening over the Next Decade in technology? Well, duh! Everything! Ten years is like a lifetime in the tech world, so obviously everything is going to change. How drastically it will change is a matter of debate though.

I've often been called a negative nanny, but I like to think of myself as a skeptic who doesn't like getting carried away. Maybe my constant adding of a pinch of salt to everything is the reason I have high BP, but I cannot help but do so.

Saying everything will change is the obvious answer, and is essentially not saying anything. This is what Ed told me when I answered his question with "Everything": This is why I bring in the good old adage into this column: "The more things change, the more they stay the same". Attributed to the nineteenth century satirical French journalist Jean-Baptiste Karr, this saying has stuck with me for a long time now, and that's him in the image, not me, because I'm an undercover writer who likes my privacy.

A reader once challenged me to diss CES, which, again, had Ed call me and wake me from a deep slumber (I'm not a night owl like most of these guys), insisting I reply to the reader right this instant. And that's exactly what I said about it, in a roundabout way.

Of course there will be new developments in technology, and of course the existing technol-

ogy we have will get better, but what really is the end goal here?

Will a cell phone camera become so awesome that it will click pictures that are better than what the human eye sees? Will headphones produce pristine sound with such high fidelity that it outdoes the human ear? What really is the pinnacle of technology when it comes to human interfacing devices? Let's face it, most of us want to know about technology that affects us directly. It's the phones, the screens, the interfaces, the assistants, the cars, etc., all of the things we interface with that we want to know more about.

Think about it though, will technology ever be able to entice you with images that are sharper or better than what your eyes are capable of seeing in the real world? To some extent, if technology allows us to experience a picture just as if we're standing there, with the ability to focus close or far, then that would be awesome, but it's limited by your eyes. Just as your ears are what limit you from hearing frequencies that you cannot hear...

You are the limit when it comes to personal technology, and we're approaching that limit pretty quick. Heck, in terms of audio, many would say we've already hit that limit.

And don't get me wrong, I'm not saying we will never surpass those limits, because I think we most certainly will eventually. We'd have to bypass our pathetic human sensory organs to do so, but that can be achieved with a direct brain interfaces. Computing at the speed of thought is when the real changes will happen, but not yet.

For the next decade I foresee the slow and steady improvement towards replicating human sensory capabilities, and even trying to mimic human intelligence (yes, that dirty word, "AI"), which will not be as exciting as, say, being one of the first few people to play Pong back in the 1970s.

We're in a phase where the changes only really enforce the status quo, and that status quo is that everyone is still trying to bring technology to human levels, when I think they should be trying to surpass us! 



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Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
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